

CDN Incident Alert: 0082. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	X-ploitation: How X Became a Crossroads for Child Abuse and Influence EU Operations	18/08/2025

Summary

- At least since May 17th, a coordinated inauthentic behaviour network has been hijacking hashtags to CSAM videos on X, exploiting the same two vulnerabilities that are exploited by Doppelganger and Operation Overload.
- The total reach is unknown, but one of the niche CSAM hashtags hijacked by the operation had over one million posts over 30 days. Each post commonly had between 1000 and 100,000 views. The operation has seemingly led to purchases of CSAM material.
- The operation is using bulk-created accounts to flood existing hashtags, and amplifying the posts by spamming the posts with comments, to make the posts reach the hashtags' "top" section on X, to sell CSAM content bundles.
- The operation has been reported to Belgian police, a child protection NGO, and X. X has not commented. X should address the underlying vulnerabilities that enable CSAM and IO.

Incident

At least since May 17, an English-language Coordinated Inauthentic Behaviour (CIB) Network named "X-ploitation" has spread CSAM on X. The operation has hijacked at least 17 hashtags on X with Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM), making the content appear in the "top" section of the hashtags' page. The CIB network's objective seems to be to sell CSAM content bundles and access to streams of content.

The operation is using one set of accounts to post tweets with CSAM content, a series of hashtags, and links to third-party platforms like websites, Discord, and Telegram. It then uses another set of accounts to amplify those tweets by commenting on them. The amplifier cluster of accounts also has another function; they either directly post links to other CSAM selling websites or tell readers to check out their profile description for such links.

The operation had initially completely taken over the "top" section of these hashtags. A few days after our 18 July flagging of two tweets, X started to rapidly take down accounts from the network. The CIB network kept adding new batches of accounts, continuing to flood the hashtags, making X's account take-downs ineffective. The underlying issues that are enabling this operation are the same that enable influence operations, like Doppelganger and Operation Overload, but also spam CIB networks. These are the ease of creating X accounts and the lack of systemic moderation that goes beyond removing individual accounts. This failure to address the underlying issue might stipulate a systemic risk, a violation of Articles 34 and 35 of the Digital Services Act.

Narrative

Meta narrative: N/A

Sub-narratives: N/A

Impact

Reach: The operation is flooding these hashtags with content, each reaching between 1000 and 100,000 views. The total amount of posts is unknown, but one of the more niche CSAM-related hashtags received over 1 million posts within a 30-day time span, according to the social listening tool Meltwater.

Outcome: Investigating one of the websites promoted, identifying a bitcoin wallet attached to the sale of CSAM, we can see that the operation is leading to the sale of CSAM. Furthermore, visitors of hashtags, such as #moms, are exposed to CSAM.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework).

Objective: [T0137: Make Money](#) – The operation is directing users to channels that sell bundles of CSAM content.

[T0150.008: Bulk Created Asset](#) – The accounts show clear signs of being bulk created, including using the same theme of profile pictures, creation dates, and naming.

[T0049.002: Flood Existing Hashtag](#) – One set of these accounts is used to flood hashtags to reach audiences.

[T0116.001: Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#) – another set of accounts are used to flood the comment sections of the CSAM posts.

[T0121: Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#) – The commenting was made to make the posts appear in the top section of the hashtag pages.

Recommendations and Actions Taken.

Actions taken: Flagged the case to X – no reply; provided case to media – article in Politico; made a formal complaint to the Belgian Police, provided evidence – pending police unit being assigned to the case; provided article to NGO Child Focus – will support us in amplification and disruption.

Recommendations: X should address the systemic issue on their platform, going beyond taking down accounts and instead focusing on addressing the ease of creating accounts; X should block the spread of specific URLs and distinct manipulative patterns of behaviour, like the one described in this case.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	N/A	Upon request	Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe. Claudia De Sessa, volunteer, Alliance4Europe. Joel Haglund, volunteer, Alliance4Europe ¹ .	X	

¹. The information and views set out in this alert are those of the volunteers and do not reflect the official opinion nor are linked to the activities of his official employer.